

INTERPRETING HIS WORD

A FRAMEWORK FOR BREAKING DOWN AND
UNDERSTANDING GOD'S WORD FOR YOURSELF

ΠΡΟΣ ΤΙΜΟΘΕΟΝ Β' 3:16-17

πάσα γραφή θεόπνευστος και ωφέλιμος
διδασκαλία, προς ἐλεγμόν, προς ἐπανόρθωσιν
παιδείαν τὴν ἐν δικαιοσύνῃ, ἵνα ἄρτιος ᾖ ὁ τοῖ
ἄνθρωπος, προς πᾶν ἔργον ἀγαθὸν ἐξηρτισμένος

ΤΑ ΛΟΥΚΑΝ 24:27

ἀρξάμενος ἀπὸ Μωϋσέως και ἀπὸ πάντων τῶν ἀρξάμενος ἀπὸ Μωϋσέως και ἀπὸ πάντων τῶν προφητῶν
διερμήνευσεν αὐτοῖς ἐν πάσαις ταῖς γραφαῖς διερμήνευσεν αὐτοῖς ἐν πάσαις ταῖς γραφαῖς τὰ περὶ αὐτοῦ

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INTERPRETING HIS WORD

THE WORD IS BORN SERIES

Once you accept Jesus as your Lord and Savior, that truth and reality is irrevocable. Still, God has a plan for you “of becoming” more like Jesus. The five foundational (Core) areas for a follower of Jesus give you a simple framework for being intentional about your spiritual growth.

C **Talking to God**
Your prayer life.

O **Knowing God’s Story**
Your understanding of God, His character, His perfect plan, His purpose and His promise throughout the biblical narrative. From Genesis to Revelation to now.

R **Understanding Your God Story**
Your ability to share your God story with others: when and why you recognized your need for God, what drew you and led you to make a lifelong commitment.

E **Interpreting His Word(s) (this volume)**
Your ability to break down, understand and apply Scripture, as it was written, to everyday life. From Genesis to Revelation: understanding context.

 **Growth: Gifting, Generosity, Christlikeness**
Your ability to reflect God’s character, command and calling in your life, through working, giving and living for God, with others.

Also in The Word Is Born series
Knowing God’s Story: The Bible Cover to Cover

THE WORD IS BORN · SERIES

INTERPRETING HIS WORD

**A FRAMEWORK FOR BREAKING
DOWN AND
UNDERSTANDING GOD'S WORD FOR
YOURSELF**

Reading Scripture with a Gospel Lens and the TOOLS Bible Study
Framework

LAWRENCE E. ADJAH

MBA, M.Ed., M.Div.

WATCH GOD WORK PUBLISHERS

Interpreting His Word: A Framework for Breaking Down and Understanding God's Word for Yourself

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The teaching on reading Scripture with a gospel lens, including the readings of Genesis 22, 1 Samuel 17 and the Old and New Testament law, draws on the work of Timothy Keller and is attributed where quoted.

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“All Scripture is God-breathed and is useful for teaching, rebuking, correcting and training in righteousness, so that the servant of God may be thoroughly equipped for every good work.”

2 TIMOTHY 3:16-17 (NIV)

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A NOTE BEFORE YOU BEGIN

My goal in this book is simple: to give you frameworks and practical tools that support your spiritual growth in this season of your life, and to put them in your hands so that you can use them without me.

A book is not a discipleship relationship. It cannot know your story, ask you the follow-up question, or notice when you have gone quiet. As such, my expectation is that you will not read this alone. Pursue what is here in community, with people who will hold you accountable to grow. Read it with a friend, a small group, a mentor, or a spouse, and let them see your notes.

For anyone seeking to grow spiritually, I encourage a commitment to community, or to a one-on-one discipleship relationship with someone you trust. Separately, I always recommend, if you have not already, seeking a faith-based counselor as well.

This book is Level 1 of the Adjah Foundations: the ground floor, built to be stood on. It is designed to be read with a Bible open beside it, and then used, again and again, at the study table. The framework at its center is called TOOLS, three layers of questions you will meet in Part Three, and the last part of this book is given over to practicing it: a worked example, practice passages and blank templates for your own studies.

One more thing. There is a science to learning this way. You do not understand a passage by reading it and nodding. You understand it by engaging with it: asking honest questions, writing them down, marking up the page, and going to find the answers. Everything that follows assumes you are holding a pen.

Lawrence E. Adjah

INTRODUCTION

ANYTHING THAT'S HEALTHY, GROWS

AN OVERVIEW OF SPIRITUAL GROWTH

Our journeys with God are unique, yet all of our journeys are universally pointing in the direction of growth.

Spiritual growth is like exercise, and in many ways the work of this book is to help you see where your need for His strength is, and to provide you with the equipment and guidance you will need to be spiritually healthy, alongside the accountability of a community. And as you know, anything that's healthy, grows.

Most importantly, God's mission is that you would each build a strong (core) foundation in Him, where you not only grow stronger spiritually, but also grow His family intentionally by learning this foundation and passing it on to others He has placed within (y)our realm of influence and responsibility.

It's a lifelong commitment to being spiritually healthy. In the same way there will always be greater physical health that one can experience, on a spiritual journey you are diving into an ocean that is infinitely deep. Said simply, once God is part of your life, His goal is to make you more like Him (Jesus) in every area of your life.

As a result, you will never arrive until Jesus returns, but you will always be invited to grow, and that requires active and intentional exercise in every area of your life.

FOUNDATIONAL AREAS

THE FIVE CORE AREAS

A SIMPLE FRAMEWORK FOR INTENTIONAL SPIRITUAL GROWTH

Once you accept Jesus as your Lord and Savior, that truth and reality is irrevocable. You don't need to earn or keep your Christian license renewed annually to maintain it. With that said, God has a plan for you "of becoming" more like Jesus, and that began prior to your mother's womb and did not end on the day you decided to follow Jesus.

The five foundational (Core) areas for a follower of Jesus help you to have a simple framework for being intentional about your spiritual growth.

To be a follower of Christ is varied, by person and context. Still, there are biblically affirmed, gospel-centered truths about the life and behaviors of every believer in Christ that must be pursued with intention:

- You must grow in your ability to communicate with God.
- You must grow in your understanding of His character, plan and promises throughout history.
- You must grow in your understanding of your story. "Always be prepared to give a reason for the hope that is in you" (1 Peter 3:15).
- You must grow in the knowledge and understanding of His words to you through the Bible.

- You must grow in your ability to use your talents for His work, your generosity and your witness, in your closest relationships.

C

TALKING TO GOD

Your prayer life.

O

KNOWING GOD'S STORY

Your understanding of God, His character, His perfect plan, His purpose and His promise throughout the biblical narrative. From Genesis to Revelation to now.

R

UNDERSTANDING YOUR GOD STORY

Your ability to share your God story with others: when and why you recognized your need for God, what drew you and led you to make a lifelong commitment.

E

INTERPRETING HIS WORD(S)

Your ability to break down, understand and apply Scripture, as it was written, to everyday life. From Genesis to Revelation: understanding context. This is the subject of this book.



GROWTH: GIFTING, GENEROSITY, CHRISTLIKENESS

Your ability to reflect God's character, command and calling in your life, through working, giving and living for God, with others.

There are levels. Infinite levels. No one will arrive at perfection in any of these areas, but the invitation (and promise) is that every follower of Jesus will grow. I simply want to help you do that with intention.

PART ONE

INTERPRETING HIS WORD

Why the Bible is about God, why its words come to us from another time and place, and what the goal of study really is.

CHAPTER 1

THE BIBLE IS ABOUT GOD

WRITTEN BY GOD, THROUGH HUMAN
AUTHORS, TO HUMAN BEINGS, OF
WHICH YOU ARE ONE

The Bible is about God. It was written by God through human authors, and it was written by God to human beings, of which you are one.

And the One who created you and the Bible wanted you to know Him, through the Bible. While God is not limited to any medium, His words were intended to empower us to see Him as He is and to be who He's called us to be.

This is a supernatural process. It is supernatural in more ways than one, because it is only through God's power that the book is written, perfected and understood. And that's the thing: because we were made to know God, God made everything for us to know Him, including Scripture, and that's where Bible study comes in.

Now think about it. Imagine wanting to tell someone the story of your life, and they happened to live in another time and place, let's say thousands of years from now. Since we can't FedEx a reality TV reel to the future, most would agree that the best way to do it would be to have not only your words, but also witnesses, which are the words and experiences of people who knew you and knew of you, chronicle your life and everything happening in and around the world at that time, to get a fuller picture of who you are.

In many ways, it's helpful to look at God through the Bible in that way.

FOR REFLECTION

1. Before this chapter, if someone asked you what the Bible is about, what would you have said?
2. Whose words and witness would you want chronicled if someone thousands of years from now were to know you? What does that suggest about the Bible's forty authors?

CHAPTER 2

WORDS FROM ANOTHER TIME AND PLACE

WHY CONTEXT GIVES THE WORDS THEIR MEANING

Even having the words you can read and understand, the Bible was written in a time and a context that is much different than the times and context you're living in now. The times and context give meaning to the words, norms and activities in ways that make them a language in and of itself. Eye contact in one place may mean respect and in another may mean disrespect. A custom in one place expresses honor and in another expresses dishonor.

We can't simply take words and events at face value and think we can understand what they mean. Exploring what the Scripture means to you, devoid of understanding what it was intended to mean to the people it was written to and for, is a path to misunderstanding God's Word. Study is worship, and out of that comes understanding and transformation, for you and those around you.

The better equipped you are to study God's Word, the more effective you are at drawing from the infinite well of power that it contains, to see God as He is and to see and be who He's called you to be. As His child, He wants you to be able to understand His voice and be transformed by His words. Thus He wants all of His children to be able to interpret and understand His words on their own.

KEY PRINCIPLE

A text cannot mean what it could never have meant for its original hearers and readers.

FOR REFLECTION

1. Name one passage you have applied to your life without ever asking what it meant to its first hearers.
2. What custom or phrase in Scripture has confused you because it belonged to another world?
3. How does “study is worship” change the posture you bring to the page?

CHAPTER 3

THAT YOU WOULD SEE GOD

THE GOAL OF EVERY STUDY

It is not simply that you would have more knowledge, but rather that you would have more relationship, more connection with the One this is all about.

It is not simply that your head would expand with knowledge, but that your heart would expand with love. It is that you would see that His thoughts, His words, God Himself, is so much better than anything you could ask, think or imagine.

It is that you would see God.

Some would summarize the Bible in two words: *God saves*. Or: *God loves*. Still, regardless of which one you prefer, the common thread is that they all point back to God. May your studies do the same and more.

The rest of this book is a Level 1 guide to help you better interpret and understand God's Word through your studies. Part Two shows you the lenses. Part Three hands you the tools. Part Four puts them in your hands.

FOR REFLECTION

1. Where has your Bible reading been aimed at expanding your head more than your heart?
2. What would change in your study this week if you began by asking, “What am I learning about God?”

PART TWO

READING SCRIPTURE WITH A GOSPEL LENS

Encountering words of life. How the early church read the Bible, and why we should read it the same way.

CHAPTER 4

THE CORRECT LENSES

SEEING JESUS IN EVERY PART OF SCRIPTURE

The most important thing about approaching Scripture is reading it through the correct lenses. In Luke 24, as Jesus talked with some of His followers on the Emmaus road, He said to them:

“How foolish you are, and how slow to believe all that the prophets have spoken! Did not the Messiah have to suffer these things and then enter his glory?” And beginning with Moses and all the Prophets, he explained to them what was said in all the Scriptures concerning himself.

LUKE 24:25-27 (NIV)

Later, in the same chapter, as Jesus was with other disciples in the upper room:

He said to them, “This is what I told you while I was still with you: Everything must be fulfilled that is written about me in the Law of Moses, the Prophets and the Psalms.” Then he opened their minds so they could understand the Scriptures.

LUKE 24:44-45 (NIV)

“The early church saw everything in the Bible, absolutely everything, as pointing to Jesus. According to the New

Testament preachers and authors, Jesus is the point of every part of the Bible, the climax of every theme of the Bible, the true and better version of every figure in the Bible. Every nook and cranny of the Bible will tell you about Jesus if you really learn to read it with the spectacles of the gospel. It's all about him."

TIMOTHY KELLER

Everything that follows in this part of the book is an argument for those spectacles, made through three case studies. We will look at a father and a son on a mountain, a shepherd boy and a giant, and the strange gap between the laws of the Old Testament and the life of the New. In each case the question is the same: what should we see?

CHAPTER 5

CASE STUDY: ABRAHAM AND ISAAC

GENESIS 22:1–8

Some time later God tested Abraham. He said to him, “Abraham!” “Here I am,” he replied. Then God said, “Take your son, your only son, whom you love—Isaac—and go to the region of Moriah. Sacrifice him there as a burnt offering on a mountain I will show you.”

GENESIS 22:1–2 (NIV)

This is perhaps one of the most misunderstood of all the biblical stories, but the clues that will lead us to a correct understanding are hidden in plain sight in the passage. Some interpretations of this story would have us believe that God is forcing us to make an antagonizing choice, like the one with which He confronted Abraham, just to prove we really love Him. Is that the case, or was there more going on than meets the eye?

On the third day Abraham looked up and saw the place in the distance. He said to his servants, “Stay here with the donkey while I and the boy go over there. We will worship and then we will come back to you.” Abraham took the wood for the burnt offering and placed it on his son Isaac, and he himself carried the fire and the knife. As the two of them went on together, Isaac

spoke up and said to his father Abraham, “Father?” “Yes, my son?” Abraham replied. “The fire and wood are here,” Isaac said, “but where is the lamb for the burnt offering?” Abraham answered, “God himself will provide the lamb for the burnt offering, my son.” And the two of them went on together.

GENESIS 22:4–8 (NIV)

WHAT SHOULD WE SEE?

Based on this text, it seems clear that Abraham and Isaac were acting out a prophecy wherein another Father would later give His only Son as an offering for sin on the very same spot. As with Abraham and Isaac, this Father and Son would be doing so by prior agreement, in this case one made before the foundation of the world was laid, where the innocent Lamb of God would die in our place.

The conclusion: “Now I know that you love me, because you did not withhold your only son.”

FOR REFLECTION

1. Reread Genesis 22:1–14. Which details did you notice this time that you had read past before?
2. “We will come back to you.” “God himself will provide the lamb.” What do Abraham’s words reveal about what he believed?
3. Where do you hear John 3:16 in this chapter?

CHAPTER 6

HOW THE EARLY CHURCH READ SCRIPTURE

ONE UNFOLDING, TRUE STORY OF THE WHOLE WORLD

Our approach rests on three foundations: the historical foundations for reading Scripture laid by the early church, the unity of the Old Testament and New Testament Scriptures, and a set of tools and frameworks for understanding Scripture. This chapter takes the first.

HOW DID THE EARLY CHURCH READ SCRIPTURE?

The Bible was read as a single, unfolding, true story of the whole world, which points ultimately and purposefully to Christ. When the early church used the word “Scripture,” they were referring to the teachings of the Old Testament that pointed to the coming of Jesus. The way in which this story points to Christ is twofold.

First, Christ is the hero of the story because of His death, burial and resurrection. This is the gospel. Second, the body of Christ is called to play a supporting role in this story through gospel proclamation and mission. It is with those two lenses that Jesus, and the early church, read and interpreted Scripture.

WHY DID THEY READ SCRIPTURE THIS WAY?

Though the Bible contains the voices of many different witnesses (forty authors and sixty-six books), the canon of Scripture finds its unity in the overarching story of the work of the triune God. God is the author of Scripture's unity.

KEY PRINCIPLE

There are, in the end, only two ways to read the Bible: is it basically about me, or basically about Jesus?

FOR REFLECTION

1. Which way have you mostly read the Bible: as basically about you, or basically about Jesus?
2. Choose an Old Testament story you know well. Where might it be pointing to Christ?
3. Why do you think Jesus began with Moses and the Prophets rather than simply announcing Himself?

CHAPTER 7

CASE STUDY: DAVID AND GOLIATH

I SAMUEL 17

Look at the story of David and Goliath. What is the meaning of that narrative for us? Without reference to Christ, the story may be (and usually is!) read as:

“The bigger they come, the harder they’ll fall, if you just go into your battles with faith in the Lord. You may not be real big and powerful in yourself, but with God on your side, you can overcome giants.”

But as soon as we ask, “How is David foreshadowing the work of his greater Son?” we begin to see the same features of the story in a different light.

WHAT SHOULD WE SEE?

The story is telling us that the Israelites cannot go up against Goliath. They can’t do it. They are helpless and need a substitute. When David goes in on their behalf, he is not a full-grown man, but a vulnerable and weak figure, a mere boy. He goes virtually as a sacrificial lamb. But God uses his apparent weakness as the means to destroy the giant, and David

becomes Israel's champion-redeemer, so that his victory will be imputed to them. They get all the fruit of having fought the battle themselves.

This is a fundamentally different meaning than the one that arises from the non-Christocentric reading.

There is, in the end, only two ways to read the Bible: is it basically about me, or basically about Jesus? In other words, is it basically about what I must do, or basically about what He has done? If I read David and Goliath as basically giving me an example, then the story is really about me. I must summon up the faith and courage to fight the giants in my life. But if I read David and Goliath as basically showing me salvation through Jesus, then the story is really about Him. Until I see that Jesus fought the real giants (sin, law, death) for me, I will never have the courage to be able to fight ordinary giants in life (suffering, disappointment, failure, criticism, hardship).

For example, how can I ever fight the "giant" of failure, unless I have a deep security that God will not abandon me? If I see David as my example, the story will never help me fight the failure giant. But if I see David, and Jesus, as my substitute, whose victory is imputed to me, then I can stand before the failure giant.

FOR REFLECTION

1. Which "giant" have you been trying to fight before seeing that Jesus already fought the real ones?
2. What is the difference, in your own words, between reading David as your example and reading David as your substitute?
3. Where else in Scripture have you read a moral lesson where the text was showing you a Savior?

CHAPTER 8

CASE STUDY: MAKING SENSE OF THE OLD AND NEW TESTAMENTS

CEREMONIAL LAW, MORAL LAW AND THE COMING OF CHRIST

The Old Testament devotes a good amount of space to describing the various sacrifices offered in the tabernacle (and later the temple) to atone for sin, so that worshipers could approach a holy God. There was also a complex set of rules for ceremonial purity and cleanness. You could only approach God in worship if you ate certain foods and not others, wore certain forms of dress, refrained from touching a variety of objects, and so on. This vividly conveyed, over and over, that human beings are spiritually unclean and can't go into God's presence without purification.

But even in the Old Testament, many writers hinted that the sacrifices and the temple worship regulations pointed forward to something beyond them (see 1 Samuel 15:21–22; Psalms 50:12–15; 51:17; Hosea 6:6). When Christ appeared, He declared all foods clean (Mark 7:19), and He ignored the Old Testament cleanliness laws in other ways, touching lepers and dead bodies.

The reason is clear. When He died on the cross, the veil in the temple tore, showing that He had done away with the need for the entire

sacrificial system with all its cleanliness laws. Jesus is the ultimate sacrifice for sin, and now Jesus makes us clean.

The entire book of Hebrews explains that the Old Testament ceremonial laws were not so much abolished as fulfilled by Christ. Whenever we pray “in Jesus’ name,” we “have confidence to enter the Most Holy Place by the blood of Jesus” (Hebrews 10:19). It would, therefore, be deeply inconsistent with the teaching of the Bible as a whole if we continued to follow the ceremonial laws.

LAW STILL BINDING

The New Testament gives us further guidance about how to read the Old Testament. Paul makes it clear in places like Romans 13:8 and following that the apostles understood the Old Testament moral law to still be binding on us. In short, the coming of Christ changed how we worship, but not how we live. The moral law outlines God’s own character: His integrity, love and faithfulness. And so everything the Old Testament says about loving our neighbor, caring for the poor, generosity with our possessions, social relationships and commitment to our family is still in force. The New Testament continues to forbid killing or committing adultery, and all the sexual ethic of the Old Testament is restated throughout the New Testament (Matthew 5:27–30; 1 Corinthians 6:9–20; 1 Timothy 1:8–11). If the New Testament has reaffirmed a commandment, then it is still in force for us today.

SINS REMAIN, PENALTIES CHANGE

The New Testament explains another change between the testaments. Sins continue to be sins, but the penalties change. In the Old Testament, sins like adultery or incest were punishable with civil sanctions like execution. This is because at that time God’s people constituted a nation-state, and so all sins had civil penalties.

But in the New Testament the people of God are an assembly of churches all over the world, living under many different governments. The church is not a civil government, and so sins are dealt with by exhortation and, at worst, exclusion from membership. This is how Paul deals with a case of incest in the Corinthian church (1 Corinthians 5:1 and following; 2 Corinthians 2:7–11). Why this change? Under Christ, the gospel is not confined to a single nation. It has been released to go into all cultures and peoples.

KEY PRINCIPLE

Once you grant the main premise of the Bible, the surpassing significance of Christ and His salvation, then all the various parts of the Bible make sense.

Because of Christ, the ceremonial law is repealed. Because of Christ, the church is no longer a nation-state imposing civil penalties. It all falls into place. However, if you reject the idea of Christ as Son of God and Savior, then, of course, the Bible is at best a mishmash containing some inspiration and wisdom, but most of it would have to be rejected as foolish or erroneous.

FOR REFLECTION

1. Which Old Testament laws have confused you? Are they ceremonial, civil or moral?
2. How does the book of Hebrews reframe the sacrificial system for you?
3. Where does your life reflect that Christ changed how we worship, but not how we live?

PART THREE

TOOLS FOR UNDERSTANDING SCRIPTURE

Our goal is to hear and understand the words as the original recipients were to have heard them: the original intended meaning.

CHAPTER 9

TWO C'S AND AN OP

CONTEXT, CONTENT, AND OCCASION / PURPOSE

Our goal is to hear and understand the words as the original recipients were to have heard them: the original intended meaning. “A text cannot mean what it could never have meant for its original hearers and readers.” Thus, in Scripture you have two C’s and an OP to learn more about God.

C **CONTEXT**

Historical. The time and culture of the author and audience: the geographical, topographical and political factors that were relevant to the author’s setting and the historical occasion of the book. This is where the occasion and purpose live.

Literary. Seeing how the words have meaning in relation to other words, sentences and paragraphs, and, above all, how the genre of the book shapes what its words are doing. The next chapter is devoted to genre.

C **CONTENT**

The meaning of words, their grammatical relationships in sentences, and the choice of the original text where the manuscripts (handwritten copies) differ from one another. Remember: these are translations. The Old Testament was written in Hebrew, the New Testament in Greek. You can look up the original words to get the true sense of what was being communicated, and see where else a word is used and in what context.

OP **OCCASION / PURPOSE**

What was happening that caused this book to be written, and what did the author intend it to do for that audience at that time? Every passage sits inside a book that was written for a reason.

FOR REFLECTION

1. Pick a book of the Bible you are in now. Can you name its historical context and its occasion?
2. When was the last time you looked up an original Hebrew or Greek word? What did it change?

CHAPTER 10

THE IMPORTANCE OF GENRE

LITERARY CONTEXT: KNOW YOUR INTERPRETIVE KEYS

Based on the type of book, the genre will inform how you interpret it. The Bible is a library, not a single volume, and each kind of book asks to be read on its own terms. Below are the major genres, the interpretive key for each, an example, and the books that belong to it.

1. HISTORICAL NARRATIVE

Some books of Scripture (for example, Joshua) are primarily historical narrative, while other books (for example, Isaiah) contain sections of historical narrative.

INTERPRETIVE KEY

Cataloguing the history of God's people in real time. Real stories about real people and real situations. Historical narratives seek to tell the history, not necessarily remark on the morality of the choices that were being made.

EXAMPLE · 1 SAMUEL 13:1-4 (ESV)

Saul lived for one year and then became king, and when he had reigned for two years over Israel, Saul chose three thousand men of Israel. Two thousand were with Saul in Michmash and the hill country of Bethel, and a thousand were with Jonathan in Gibeah of Benjamin. The rest of the people he sent home, every man to his tent. Jonathan defeated the garrison of the Philistines that was at Geba, and the Philistines heard of it. And Saul blew the trumpet throughout all the land, saying, "Let the Hebrews hear." And all Israel heard it said that Saul had defeated the garrison of the Philistines, and also that Israel had become a stench to the Philistines. And the people were called out to join Saul at Gilgal.

Books: Genesis and the first half of Exodus, Numbers, Joshua, Judges, Ruth, 1 and 2 Samuel, 1 and 2 Kings, 1 and 2 Chronicles, Ezra, Nehemiah, Esther, Jonah, and possibly Acts. The Gospels (Matthew, Mark, Luke, John) are their own kind of narrative: eyewitness accounts of the life of Jesus.

2. THE LAW

God's instructions to His people on how to worship Him and live before Him as a nation.

INTERPRETIVE KEY

Read the law in light of chapter 8. Ceremonial law is fulfilled in Christ, civil penalties belonged to Israel as a nation-state, and the moral law, which outlines God's own character, remains in force.

Books: The last half of Exodus, Leviticus, Deuteronomy.

3. PROPHECY AND APOCALYPTIC

Some books of Scripture are primarily prophetic (for example, Jeremiah, Zechariah), while other books (for example, Revelation) are apocalyptic.

INTERPRETIVE KEY

Employing metaphoric and symbolic language to announce judgment, blessing and hope for the people of God. Often the prophet accomplishes this by describing things from God's vantage point.

EXAMPLE · ISAIAH 5:5 (ESV)

And now I will tell you what I will do to my vineyard. I will remove its hedge, and it shall be devoured; I will break down its wall, and it shall be trampled down.

EXAMPLE · REVELATION 15:2 (ESV)

I saw what appeared to be a sea of glass mingled with fire, and also those who had conquered the beast and its image and the number of its name, standing beside the sea of glass with harps of God in their hands.

Prophecy: Isaiah, Jeremiah, Ezekiel, Daniel, Hosea, Joel, Amos, Obadiah, Jonah, Micah, Nahum, Habakkuk, Zephaniah, Haggai, Zechariah, Malachi. **Apocalypse:** Daniel, Revelation.

4. POETRY AND WISDOM

Poetry then and now. Poems appeal to the whole person in a way that history does not. They stimulate our imaginations, arouse our emotions, feed our intellects and address our wills.

EXAMPLE · EXODUS 15:1–5 (ESV)

Then Moses and the people of Israel sang this song to the Lord: “I will sing to the Lord, for he has triumphed gloriously; the horse and his rider he has thrown into the sea. The Lord is my strength and my song, and he has become my salvation; this is my God, and I will praise him, my father’s God, and I will exalt him. The Lord is a man of war; the Lord is his name. Pharaoh’s chariots and his host he cast into the sea, and his chosen officers were sunk in the Red Sea. The floods covered them; they went down into the depths like a stone.”

INTERPRETIVE KEY

Notice relationships between lines. Often meaning resides in clarification and/or contrast. Imagery is also a significant part of Hebrew poetry. Historical context is generally not as determinative for meaning.

EXAMPLES · PSALM 23:1–2 (ESV) · PROVERBS 3:5–6 (NIV)

The Lord is my shepherd; I shall not want. He makes me lie down in green pastures.

Trust in the Lord with all your heart and lean not on your own understanding; in all your ways submit to him, and he will make your paths straight.

Wisdom: Job, Proverbs, Ecclesiastes. **Psalms and poetry:** Psalms, Song of Solomon, Lamentations.

5. DIDACTIC: THE EPISTLES

A distinctly New Testament genre.

INTERPRETIVE KEY

Letters are instructional and occasional. They were written to particular people, in particular situations, to address particular things.

EXAMPLE · 1 TIMOTHY 1:2–4 (ESV)

To Timothy, my true child in the faith: Grace, mercy, and peace from God the Father and Christ Jesus our Lord. As I urged you when I was going to Macedonia, remain at Ephesus so that you may charge certain persons not to teach any different doctrine, nor to devote themselves to myths and endless genealogies, which promote speculations rather than the stewardship from God that is by faith.

EXAMPLE · ROMANS 12:1 (ESV)

I appeal to you therefore, brothers, by the mercies of God, to present your bodies as a living sacrifice, holy and acceptable to God, which is your spiritual worship.

Books: Romans, 1 and 2 Corinthians, Galatians, Ephesians, Philippians, Colossians, 1 and 2 Thessalonians, 1 and 2 Timothy, Titus, Philemon, Hebrews, James, 1 and 2 Peter, 1, 2 and 3 John, Jude.

FOR REFLECTION

1. How does the genre of the book you are reading change what you expect the text to do?
2. Which genre have you most often read as though it were a different one, for example, narrative as a set of morality lessons?

CHAPTER 11

THE TOOLS STUDY FRAMEWORK

A THREE-LAYER APPROACH: BACKGROUND, UNDERGROUND, NEW GROUND

Every passage gets the same treatment, in the same order. You dig down before you build up. Background establishes the world of the text. Underground takes you into the text itself. New Ground is where the text comes home to you. The letters are meant to be memorized so that the questions become reflex.

PRAYER: "PRAY TO ASK ABBA (FATHER) FOR DIRECTION"

Have I asked for God's help in bringing His words to (real) life for me?

BACKGROUND

The book that contains the passage

A	Who is the Author?	What should you know about them?
A	Who is the Audience?	What should you know about them?
G	What is the Genre?	How should it inform your study?
P	What is the Purpose of the book?	Why did the author write it?
S	Social, cultural and economic norms?	What was the world like at the time?

UNDERGROUND

Into the text itself

R	Read the text	Have I read the chapter and the section?
I	Interrogate the text	What questions arise for you?
P	Picture and process the text	Where are we in God's redemptive story?

CREATION · FALL · REDEMPTION · RENEWAL · RESTORATION

NEW GROUND

Bringing it home

G	Give: What is this saying?	Layman's terms, a child's summary.
O	Observations: What is this showing?	About God's character, about humanity.
D	Decide	Where I see me, where God sees me, where God delivers me.

The next two chapters take each layer in turn.

CHAPTER 12

BACKGROUND: BEFORE YOU OPEN THE PASSAGE

AUTHOR, AUDIENCE, GENRE, PURPOSE AND SETTING

The first layer is about the book, not the passage. Read the book that contains the passage before diving into the passage. If you are studying Philippians 2, read all of Philippians.

A WHO IS THE AUTHOR, AND WHAT SHOULD YOU KNOW ABOUT THEM?

Who wrote the book? Moses, unknown, Paul? Understanding the author's background, experiences and relationship with God illuminates the text.

A WHO IS THE AUDIENCE?

Who was this book specifically written to at the time, besides us? For example, the Israelites whom Moses led through the wilderness, or the church at Corinth.

G WHAT IS THE GENRE?

What type of book is it? Historical narrative, Gospel, epistle, the Law, wisdom, Psalms, prophecy or apocalypse. Based on the type of book, it will inform how you interpret it. Use chapter 10 as your reference.

P **WHAT IS THE PURPOSE?**

What was the purpose of the entire book? What was the occasion, and what was the reason for the author to write it to that audience at that time?

S **WHAT IS THE SOCIAL AND CULTURAL BACKGROUND?**

This seeks to understand the text based on the cultural and historical events, elements and norms taking place at the time it was written.

FOR REFLECTION

1. When was the last time you prayed before you read? What did you ask for?
2. For the book you are in now, which of the five Background questions can you not yet answer? Where will you look?

CHAPTER 13

UNDERGROUND AND NEW GROUND

READ, INTERROGATE AND PICTURE THE TEXT, THEN GIVE, OBSERVE AND DECIDE

UNDERGROUND

R READ THE TEXT

Have I read the full chapter and the section? Before going deep on a passage, read the entire book for context.

I INTERROGATE THE TEXT

This is the most important part of your study: listing all the questions you have about the passage as you are reading it. Include words you don't know, things that don't make sense, and connections you are curious about. Then pursue answers.

Be honest about your questions. The ones you are embarrassed to ask are usually the ones that unlock the passage. There is a science to learning this way: a question you write down and chase is remembered; a sentence you read and nod at is not. Mark up the page. Underline what stands out, circle what confuses you, draw the connections in the margin.

Keep a separate list of word definitions you want to research further, and remember that these are translations: look up the original Hebrew or Greek words to get the true sense of what was being communicated. Chapter 14 tells you where to look.

P PICTURE AND PROCESS THE TEXT

Where are we in God's redemptive story? Place the passage within the grand arc: Creation, Fall, Redemption, Renewal, Restoration.

NEW GROUND

G GIVE: WHAT IS THIS SAYING?

Interpret the passage in verbal layman's terms, line by line. Could a child understand your summary? This forces clarity and exposes what you actually understand versus what you are glossing over.

O **OBSERVATIONS: WHAT IS THIS SHOWING?**

About God. Where does God show up in the passage? What am I learning about God's character through the passage? God may not necessarily be called out, but it may point you back to Him. Based on your growing knowledge of God, how do you think God feels about what is happening? Why?

About humanity. What am I understanding about the people in this passage, and what am I seeing about human nature? Put yourself in the shoes of each major character and draw out the feelings, conflicts and emotions as though you were going through it yourself. It helps you connect to what is being described in a way that illuminates the passage and its applications. Still, the focus should be rooted more on God than on you.

D **DECIDE: WHERE DO I SEE MYSELF?**

Where I see me. What is this passage saying to me?

Where God sees me. Where do I see Jesus and the gospel in this passage? Where do I see this passage pointing to Jesus?

Where God delivers me. How does this passage translate from its context to today? How do I apply it? For me, for others, for the world.

FOR REFLECTION

1. What questions came up in your last reading that you never wrote down or pursued?
2. Try it now: summarize the passage you are studying so a child could understand it.
3. What is God freeing you from, or calling you toward, through this text?

CHAPTER 14

TOOLS FOR THE TABLE

BIBLES AND RESOURCES FOR INTERROGATING THE TEXT

Interrogating the text raises questions that a single translation cannot always answer. Which Bible should I read? What did that word mean in Hebrew or Greek? Where else is it used? This chapter is a short answer to those questions, so that the resources never become the obstacle.

WHICH BIBLE

Read a translation you will actually read. My recommendation is the New International Version (NIV): faithful, readable, and the translation quoted throughout this book. Second is the English Standard Version (ESV), which sits closer to the word order of the original languages and is a strong second Bible to keep open beside the first. Reading a passage in both, side by side, is one of the simplest ways to notice a word worth chasing.

A study Bible in either translation adds introductions to each book that answer most of the Background questions (author, audience, genre, purpose, setting) before you begin.

LOOKING UP THE ORIGINAL WORDS

You do not need to know Hebrew or Greek to look behind a translation. These free tools show you the original word under any English word, its definition, and every other place it appears in Scripture:

- **Blue Letter Bible** (blueletterbible.org). Click any verse, choose the interlinear view, and every word links to its Strong's number, definition and occurrences.
- **Bible Hub** (biblehub.com). Interlinear text, parallel translations on one page, and lexicon entries for each word.
- **STEP Bible** (stepbible.org), from Tyndale House, Cambridge. Original-language text with vocabulary and grammar, built for students without formal training.
- **Bible Gateway** (biblegateway.com). The fastest way to read a passage in several translations at once.

For deeper study, Logos and Accordance are the standard paid libraries, and a good exhaustive concordance in print does the same work without a screen.

HOW TO USE THEM

Start with your question, not the tool. Write the question in your Underground notes, look up the word, record what you find in your word definitions list, and then ask the next question. The goal is not to collect information. It is to hear the words as the first readers heard them, and then to see God.

PART FOUR

THE TEMPLATE IN PRACTICE

A worked example, three practice passages, and blank templates for your own studies.

CHAPTER 15

A WORKED EXAMPLE: GENESIS 25:19–34

JACOB AND ESAU, FOR ILLUSTRATIVE PURPOSES

What follows is a sample study of a single passage, done the way the template asks. It is illustrative, not exhaustive. Notice how much of the work is simply asking honest questions and then going to find answers.

BACKGROUND

Author: Moses (traditionally). **Audience:** the Israelites whom Moses led through the wilderness. **Genre:** historical narrative; real people, real situations, history rather than morality lessons. **Purpose:** Genesis tells the beginning of everything, from creation to sin to the people of Israel, so that a nation on the way to the Promised Land would know whose they were and where they came from. **Setting:** a patriarchal, nomadic culture in which birthright and blessing carried sacred weight.

INTERROGATING THE TEXT

This is the most important part of your study: listing all the questions you have about the passage as you are reading it, and then the answers you find.

- What is the significance of Esau being red?
 - Some say it is tied to ruggedness and manliness.
 - The adjective refers to the skin rather than the hair, as in the case of David (1 Samuel 16:12). The Hebrew for “red,” *admoni*, is intended as a play on the word “Edom,” as if the Edomites were known as “the Reds” on account of their warm complexion.
- What is the significance of twins in the Bible?
 - Unsure if there is one.
 - Perez and Zerah: Judah’s daughter-in-law, Tamar, was widowed and did not want to be childless. Disguising herself, she intercepts Judah on the road. The result of their union was Perez and Zerah (Genesis 38:12–30). From Perez would come the family of David (Ruth 4:18–22).
- What is the importance of birthrights?
 - The Jews attached a sacred importance to the rank of “first-born” and “first-begotten,” as applied to the Messiah (Romans 8:29; Colossians 1:18; Hebrews 1:4–6). As first-born He has an inheritance superior to His brethren, and is alone the true priest.
 - The word denotes the special privileges and advantages belonging to the first-born son among the Jews. He became the priest of the family. Thus Reuben was the first-born of the patriarchs, and so the priesthood of the tribes belonged to him. That honor was, however, transferred by God from Reuben to Levi (Numbers 3:12–13; 8:18).

WORD DEFINITIONS

Words you want to research further. Remember these are translations: the Old Testament was written in Hebrew, the New Testament in Greek. Look up the original words, see where else they are used, and in what context.

- *Admoni* (red, ruddy). *Bekorah* (birthright). *Edom*.

PICTURE AND PROCESS

Where are we in God's redemptive story? After the Fall, inside the promise to Abraham, before the nation and before the King. God is choosing the line through which redemption will come, and He is choosing the younger.

GIVE: WHAT IS THIS SAYING?

In layman's terms, line by line: Isaac prays for his wife who cannot have children, and God answers. Twins wrestle inside her, and God tells her the older will serve the younger. Esau is born red and hairy, Jacob born holding his heel. Esau grows into a hunter and Isaac's favorite; Jacob stays near the tents and is Rebekah's favorite. One day Esau comes in famished and trades his birthright to Jacob for a bowl of stew. So Esau despised his birthright.

OBSERVATIONS: WHAT IS THIS SHOWING?

About God. God answers prayer, and He speaks before either child has done anything. His choice does not depend on birth order, strength or the parents' preferences. He keeps His promise to Abraham through unlikely people.

About humanity. Stand in each pair of shoes. Isaac and Rebekah, each with a favorite. Esau, driven by appetite, willing to sell the sacred for the immediate. Jacob, grasping from birth, shrewd at his brother's expense. Human nature trades eternal things for a bowl of something hot.

DECIDE

Where I see me. Where am I Esau, treating what God has given as cheap when I am hungry? Where am I Jacob, grasping for what God has already promised?

Where God sees me. The true first-born, Jesus, did not despise His inheritance; He shared it. He is the one "to whom belongs the birthright," and He gives His brethren a place in it (Hebrews 1:4–6; Romans 8:29).

Where God delivers me. For me: name the bowl of stew I keep trading for. For others: whom am I favoring, and at what cost? For the world: God's purposes run through the unlikely and the undeserving, which is good news for everyone.

CHAPTER 16

PRACTICE EXERCISES

APPLY THE TOOLS FRAMEWORK TO THREE PASSAGES

Now the work. For each passage below, move through all three layers: Background, then Underground, then New Ground. Do not skip the prayer. Do not skip reading the whole book first. Then answer the three questions below.

FOR EACH PASSAGE, ASK

1. What stuck out to you in the passage? (What did you observe?)
2. Where do we see Jesus Christ in these verses?
3. Why are these verses in the Bible? (Try to summarize God's purpose in putting these particular words in the Bible.)

Joshua 1:1–7

Historical narrative

God's charge to Joshua after Moses' death: courage, obedience and the promise of His presence.

Psalms 16:5–11

Poetry / Psalms

David's declaration of trust and joy in God's presence: a messianic psalm pointing to resurrection.

Philippians 1:27–30

Didactic / Epistle

Paul's call to conduct worthy of the gospel: unity, faith and the gift of suffering for Christ.

CHAPTER 17

YOUR STUDY TEMPLATES

THREE BLANK TEMPLATES FOR YOUR OWN PASSAGES

Each template runs four pages and follows the framework exactly: Background for the book, then Underground and New Ground for the passage. Photocopy them, or use them as the pattern for a notebook of your own. Begin every study the same way: “Pray to ask Abba (Father) for direction.”

Study is worship.

STUDY TEMPLATE 1 • BACKGROUND

BOOK

Passage _____ Date _____

Prayer: Have I asked for God's help? _____

A • WHO IS THE AUTHOR, AND WHAT SHOULD I KNOW ABOUT THEM?

A • WHO IS THE AUDIENCE?

G • WHAT IS THE GENRE, AND HOW SHOULD IT INFORM MY STUDY?

P • WHAT IS THE PURPOSE OF THE BOOK? WHY DID THE AUTHOR WRITE IT?

S • SOCIAL, CULTURAL AND ECONOMIC NORMS OF THE TIME

STUDY TEMPLATE 1 · UNDERGROUND

PASSAGE

R · READ THE TEXT. HAVE I READ THE CHAPTER, THE SECTION AND THE BOOK?

I · INTERROGATE THE TEXT: QUESTIONS, AND THE ANSWERS
I FIND

WORD DEFINITIONS TO RESEARCH

P · PICTURE AND PROCESS: WHERE ARE WE IN GOD'S REDEMPTIVE STORY?

Creation · Fall · Redemption · Renewal · Restoration

STUDY TEMPLATE 1 • NEW GROUND

PASSAGE

G • GIVE: WHAT IS THIS SAYING? (LAYMAN'S TERMS, LINE BY LINE)

O • OBSERVATIONS: WHAT AM I LEARNING ABOUT GOD IN THE PASSAGE?

Where does God show up? What am I learning about His character? How do you think He feels about what is happening, and why?

O • WHAT AM I SEEING ABOUT THE PEOPLE, AND ABOUT HUMAN NATURE?

Put yourself in the shoes of each major character.

STUDY TEMPLATE 1 · NEW GROUND

APPLICATION

D · WHERE I SEE ME: WHAT IS THIS PASSAGE SAYING TO ME?

D · WHERE GOD SEES ME: WHERE DO I SEE JESUS AND THE GOSPEL IN THIS PASSAGE?

D · WHERE GOD DELIVERS ME: HOW DOES THIS TRANSLATE FROM ITS CONTEXT TO TODAY?

For me

For others

For the world

STUDY TEMPLATE 2 · BACKGROUND

BOOK

Passage _____ Date _____

Prayer: Have I asked for God's help? _____

A · WHO IS THE AUTHOR, AND WHAT SHOULD I KNOW ABOUT THEM?

A · WHO IS THE AUDIENCE?

G · WHAT IS THE GENRE, AND HOW SHOULD IT INFORM MY STUDY?

P · WHAT IS THE PURPOSE OF THE BOOK? WHY DID THE AUTHOR WRITE IT?

S · SOCIAL, CULTURAL AND ECONOMIC NORMS OF THE TIME

STUDY TEMPLATE 2 · UNDERGROUND

PASSAGE

R · READ THE TEXT. HAVE I READ THE CHAPTER, THE SECTION AND THE BOOK?

I · INTERROGATE THE TEXT: QUESTIONS, AND THE ANSWERS
I FIND

WORD DEFINITIONS TO RESEARCH

P · PICTURE AND PROCESS: WHERE ARE WE IN GOD'S REDEMPITIVE STORY?

Creation · Fall · Redemption · Renewal · Restoration

STUDY TEMPLATE 2 · NEW GROUND

PASSAGE

G · GIVE: WHAT IS THIS SAYING? (LAYMAN'S TERMS, LINE BY LINE)

O · OBSERVATIONS: WHAT AM I LEARNING ABOUT GOD IN THE PASSAGE?

Where does God show up? What am I learning about His character? How do you think He feels about what is happening, and why?

O · WHAT AM I SEEING ABOUT THE PEOPLE, AND ABOUT HUMAN NATURE?

Put yourself in the shoes of each major character.

STUDY TEMPLATE 2 · NEW GROUND

APPLICATION

D · WHERE I SEE ME: WHAT IS THIS PASSAGE SAYING TO ME?

D · WHERE GOD SEES ME: WHERE DO I SEE JESUS AND THE GOSPEL IN THIS PASSAGE?

D · WHERE GOD DELIVERS ME: HOW DOES THIS TRANSLATE FROM ITS CONTEXT TO TODAY?

For me

For others

For the world

STUDY TEMPLATE 3 · BACKGROUND

BOOK

Passage _____ Date _____

Prayer: Have I asked for God's help? _____

A · WHO IS THE AUTHOR, AND WHAT SHOULD I KNOW ABOUT THEM?

A · WHO IS THE AUDIENCE?

G · WHAT IS THE GENRE, AND HOW SHOULD IT INFORM MY STUDY?

P · WHAT IS THE PURPOSE OF THE BOOK? WHY DID THE AUTHOR WRITE IT?

S · SOCIAL, CULTURAL AND ECONOMIC NORMS OF THE TIME

STUDY TEMPLATE 3 · UNDERGROUND

PASSAGE

R · READ THE TEXT. HAVE I READ THE CHAPTER, THE SECTION AND THE BOOK?

I · INTERROGATE THE TEXT: QUESTIONS, AND THE ANSWERS I FIND

WORD DEFINITIONS TO RESEARCH

P · PICTURE AND PROCESS: WHERE ARE WE IN GOD'S REDEMPITIVE STORY?

Creation · Fall · Redemption · Renewal · Restoration

STUDY TEMPLATE 3 · NEW GROUND

PASSAGE

G · GIVE: WHAT IS THIS SAYING? (LAYMAN'S TERMS, LINE BY LINE)

O · OBSERVATIONS: WHAT AM I LEARNING ABOUT GOD IN THE PASSAGE?

Where does God show up? What am I learning about His character? How do you think He feels about what is happening, and why?

O · WHAT AM I SEEING ABOUT THE PEOPLE, AND ABOUT HUMAN NATURE?

Put yourself in the shoes of each major character.

STUDY TEMPLATE 3 · NEW GROUND

APPLICATION

D · WHERE I SEE ME: WHAT IS THIS PASSAGE SAYING TO ME?

D · WHERE GOD SEES ME: WHERE DO I SEE JESUS AND THE GOSPEL IN THIS PASSAGE?

D · WHERE GOD DELIVERS ME: HOW DOES THIS TRANSLATE FROM ITS CONTEXT TO TODAY?

For me

For others

For the world

“Now the Berean Jews were of more noble character than those in Thessalonica, for they received the message with great eagerness and examined the Scriptures every day to see if what Paul said was true.”

ACTS 17:11 (NIV)

May your studies do the same and more.
May you see God.

ABOUT THE AUTHOR

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Lawrence E. Adjah is a pastor, builder and speaker, building the infrastructure human belonging requires. His work helps people and institutions strengthen their relationships with God, with other people and with themselves, mind and body.

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The Word Is Born series grew out of the Foundations program he built and taught: a set of short, framework-driven guides on prayer, fasting, reading the Bible cover to cover and interpreting His Word, designed to strengthen a believer's relationship with God, with other people and with themselves.

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THERE ARE ONLY TWO WAYS TO READ THE BIBLE. IS IT BASICALLY ABOUT ME, OR BASICALLY ABOUT JESUS?

The Bible is about God. It was written by God through human authors, and it was written by God to human beings, of which you are one. And the One who created you and the Bible wanted you to know Him, through the Bible.

Interpreting His Word is a Level 1 foundation guide for reading Scripture the way the early church read it: as a single, unfolding, true story that points to Christ. Through case studies in Genesis, 1 Samuel and the law of the Old and New Testaments, Lawrence E. Adjah shows what changes when you put on the spectacles of the gospel. Then he hands you the TOOLS framework, three layers of questions that turn careful study into reflex, along with a worked example, practice exercises and blank templates for your own passages.

Study is worship. This is a book to read with a Bible open beside it.

Lawrence E. Adjah, MBA, M.Ed., M.Div. is a pastor, bestselling author and speaker, Founder and CEO of the Family Dinner Foundation, and narrator of the NIV audio Bible, *Lawrence E. Adjah Reads the Bible*, a #1 new release on Amazon and Audible.

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